



March 2026 50th Year of Growth 1976 - 2026



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The DGC committee meeting was held on 4 March 2026 at 7.30 pm.

The next DGC meeting will be held on **Wednesday, 11 March 2026**
7.30 pm at the RSL Hall , cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street. Doors open at 7.15pm

The speakers are Maureen and Paul Lucas who will talk about their visits to the Gardens in Australia

Committee Members 2026

President

Avril Clark

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Vice-President & Speaker

Bookings:

Pauline Webb

Treasurer:

Dr Margaret Salter

Secretary:

Virgina Roberts & Connie Lee

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Fund Raising Co-Ordinator:

Anita Lizza

Newsletter:

Rohini Padey

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Ray Brett

Esther Sim

We have had a very dry start to the year and my water tanks are exhausted. The promise of rain has been very frustrating as we watch the clouds roll over us to somewhere else. The prolonged dry spell has highlighted a few areas in my garden which are not coping well

Many years ago I was gifted some Japanese Anemones which made themselves very much at home in a long garden bed on the east side but facing west. The combination of the dry weather and hot sun has completely desiccated them and so I will be removing them and replanting with more drought tolerant plants such as Lavenders succulents. A garden bed at the back is overrun with lemon balm and tansy and really looks very messy for most of the year so I am going to cover it with cardboard, manure and straw until spring.

I'm thinking about growing pumpkins or mini cabbages and cauliflowers there. We will see! I'm always inspired by Vita Sackville West who didn't hesitate to pull plants out if they weren't working according to what she wanted.

Gardens are constantly evolving and adapting and that, for me, is the joy of them!

Happy Gardening everyone and please let us know your garden stories – we would love to hear them.

Happy Gardening

Avril

Speaker for February - Peter and Sylvia Allen aka Pete the Prunier

Pete had prepared a detailed presentation for us about Pruning Fruit trees with diagrams to demonstrate the pruning techniques. The members had a very engaged discussion with him after the presentation and he answered a lot of questions.

He spoke about summer pruning of fruit trees. We do that to limit size, making it easier to net and harvest, and increase fruit yield. Summer prune just after harvest for stone fruit (January to February, Peach February to April) to give the trees until late May to create new fruiting wood. Apples and pears ripen through to June so summer pruning (February to April) is used to reduce fruit numbers, stop biennial fruiting and increase fruit size. Pete typically prunes new growth by half.

Apples, pears, nashi, plum, cherries, citrus, kiwi fruit, grapes and autumn raspberries fruit on first year wood and/or spurs and these can be pruned back to the same place yearly. Peach, nectarine, almond, apricot, brambles, summer raspberries fruit on 2nd year wood/canes so some of last year's wood needs to be saved each pruning or there will be no fruit.

Prune to just above an outward-facing bud, not too close. Always use secateurs with the blade on the side of the bud, to avoid bruising new buds. Pete uses a powered pruner (DeWalt 35mm cut capacity).

Pete follows moon phase gardening and prunes his fruit trees during the waning moon (full moon to new moon). During this phase, the moon's gravitational pull decreases, causing sap to flow downward towards the roots rather than staying in the branches. Pruning at this time causes the tree to "bleed" less, minimizes sap loss, and reduces the risk of disease.

Pete recommended the crotch angle be opened up if it is narrow, noting that narrow, tight crotches often trap bark and leaf inside, which reduces structural strength and can rot a tree. Narrow, tight crotch angles are also prone to breaking under heavy loads.

There is an open day at his nursery on 21st march 2026 at Monbulk. Telopea Mtn Permaculture & Nursery

Garden of Hope

Last December I visited an open garden in Templestowe, known as the Garden of Hope.

This is a lovely and inspiring garden. It is moderately large, but appears larger than it really is, due to trees on neighbouring properties and vegetation hiding the fences. This can be described as what gardeners call a "borrowed landscape".

The garden was designed by the owner Jacques Chirgwin, a former oncologist (cancer doctor), and currently runs a garden design business known as Hope and Garden Design. She named the garden "Garden of Hope", as gardens can often be therapeutic for people facing difficult times, as is the case for cancer patients.

For those wishing to visit this garden, it will be open again on Sunday 19th April. I encourage you to visit this garden with your family and friends. The address is 8 Beverley Hills Drive, Templestowe. The entry fee is \$10 and part of it went to cancer research. The location is near the Pines shopping centre.

Article Courtesy - Ron Thompson

Upcoming calendar events:

Upcoming Committee Meeting:	04 March	hosted by Avril Clark, 7.30pm at 62 Pine Hill Drive Doncaster East
Upcoming Meeting:	11 March	at the RSL Hall, 7.30pm at cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street Doncaster East

Following Committee Meeting:	01 April	hosted by Avril Clark, 7.30pm at 62 Pine Hill Drive Doncaster East
Following Meeting:	08 April	at the RSL Hall, 7.30pm at cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street Doncaster East

The speaker at the next meeting will be Craig Castree who will share his tips on companion planting

Hello Gardeners All

February gave me 56mm rain. Too early for the autumn break but has sent the pumpkins rampant - ok if they put out more female flowers. There is a very modest number of pumpkin and tromboncino fruit so far. The very modest crop of beans is finished. More seed were planted. 2 are up. The rest either rotted with late February rain or are slow. See pictures below with the seedlings sprouting.

The Basil, green amaranth leaf, Malabar spinach (belatedly) and purslane - common and golden varieties are doing well. All are very nutritious. The decorative gourds (cuckoos in the pumpkin patch) were cut back and fruit given away. They had been a waste of productive space. The capsicums also have some developing green fruit. Some tomato plants look ready to remove as they have die back and most fruit have

The 2 Sth American Yacon plants are growing well as is the European Skirret (carrot family). The root crops are hidden until die back. The NZ Oca seems to have struggled in the excess heat but is battling on. Again the roots hide until winter die back.

From my Garden - Pauline



From my Bookshelf March 2026

In this series, which will run throughout the year, I am featuring books in my library which I have found useful in practical ways of setting up gardens, practical growing tips, seasonal advice and the historical development of gardens that we have today and why they are important. I hope to inspire you to seek out more information and knowledge that will assist you in your gardening experience and extend your knowledge and interest

March Book of the month.

Craig Castree Edible Gardening secrets 2021

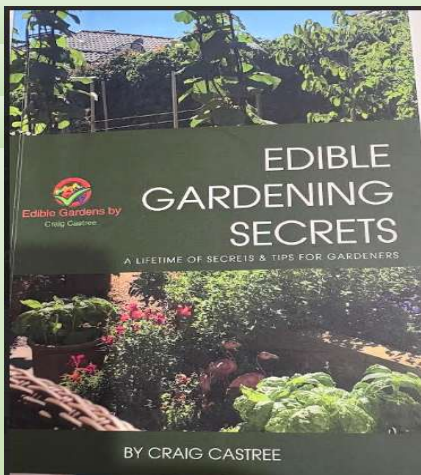
This book is the third in a trilogy of edible gardening books written by Craig Castree, a horticulturist with over 40 years of experience.

This little book is a mine of very practical information from identifying the right types of seed to garden equipment, types of soil, feeding, pruning ... This book is packed with information for the novice gardener to the experienced gardener.

Some tips I have found really useful: plant your carrot seeds with radish seeds, 'when the radish seeds germinate they grow far quicker than the carrot seeds. As the radishes grow they push the carrots sideways. When you harvest the radishes, this makes room for the carrots to grow, without you having to thin them out.

Another great tip: 'When planting things like beans, peas, zucchinis, pumpkins, melons, cucumbers you should always plant two in the same hole and thin out the weaker one...'

A great little book packed full of tips and well worth investing in. Buy your copy when Craig Castree speaks here at the Club next month !



If you would like to buy some plants and support a wonderful local organisation head to Kevin Heinze who have a 25% off plant sale from March 16 2026 to 21 March 2026

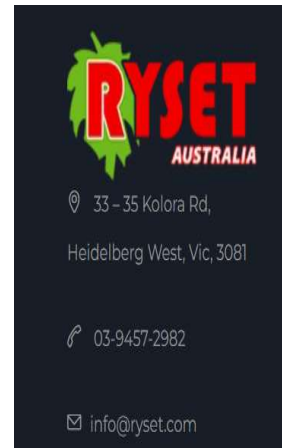
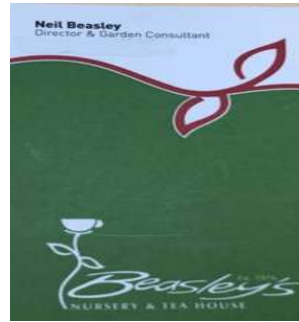
DGC Life Members	
Gerda van der Peet Doug Brewer Ken Beer Toni Myers Gayle McCann	Ted Page Joanne Driver Elsie Carter Bev Turner Franziska Kung

Doncaster Garden Club Inc. Membership 2026

Annual fees are due every October, those who have not paid for 2026 please do so at your earliest

Please complete the membership form on the Clubs website:
<https://doncastergardenclubaus.com/becomeamember>

Newsletters are emailed every month. For those wishing a hard-copy, please provide a self-addressed stamped envelope to the Club Secretary Connie or Virginia.



The Catalogue can be found online : <https://ryset.com>
The Club receives wholesale prices which means discounts of up to 60-70%

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